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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

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Section Title(S): AVOIDANCE OF NAMES • MODESTY

!Kung modesty is expressed also in their habits of urinating and defecating. All but young children who are not yet trained go well away from the encampment and squat behind bushes or in tall grass out of sight, thus combining cleanliness with modesty.

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AVOIDANCE OF NAMES

To use a person's name in direct address connotes intimacy to the !Kung.² Adults who have the joking relationship may address each other by name, but people who do not joke—people who *_koa* each other (respect, avoid, fear each other)—avoid this. Children's names are not avoided by adults or by other children. One does not begin to avoid using a person's name until that person is old enough to have children of his own.

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In general, the same restriction applies to the use of a person's name in reference, but here a fine distinction is made between speaking of a person's name and speaking of the person by name. When informants gave me genealogical information, they did not hesitate to say the names of any of their relatives, dead or alive, but they would frame their replies so that they were talking about the relative's name rather than about the relative himself. Speaking of his father, an informant would say "My father's name is [or was] Tsamgao," but he would not say "Tsamgao is [was] my father."

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A !Kung avoids referring to dead people by name, regardless of whether or not he accorded them reserved behavior in life. A dead person is referred to as *!kwa ju*. *Ju* means "person." Our interpreter, Kernel Ledimo, did not know how to translate *!kwa*. He said that it seems to be a word the !Kung use when they want to avoid saying "dead" (*!khh*); he thought its equivalent in English might be "late" ("the late Mr. So-and-so").

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Avoiding their names shows respect for the dead, but the !Kung have another reason as well. The dead become // *gauwasi* ("spirits of the dead") and live in the sky with the gods. The gods and the spirits of the dead dislike hearing their names uttered. "Who is calling my name?" they say. Their displeasure is drawn to the speaker, and they might show it by sending a sickness to him.

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The !Kung use the avoidance of names not only to express their reserve  246 toward people they *koa*; they also show respect to their elders (whatever the relationship) by avoiding their names in direct address. Children do not address adults by name; adults do not address by name persons appreciably older than themselves. I did not find precise rules defining the age-boundaries.

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2. /Qui observed that the use of first names has the same connotation for us: he noted that some members of our staff called me Madame some Mrs. Marshall, and that my children called me mother or mom, and that only my husband and some expedition members called me Lorna.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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